

Episode 95: Extra Edition – Summer Has Come!

The Kantou-Koushin'etsu region made its rainy season ending declaration at the beginning of this week. The Tokyo area has been producing consecutive midsummer days in the low thirties celsius.

Whew~, it's here! Summer!

When it comes to summer, it's anime movie season! (←stated definitively!)

So, postponing numerous urgent jobs to make time (sorry > everyone involved), I went to see this summer's two hot topic works! *Evangelion: 2.0 You Can (Not) Advance* and *Summer Wars*. Both were works that stirred my creator's heart and anime artisan's soul.

Now then.

First, *Evangelion: 2.0 You Can (Not) Advance*.

It was simply "magnificent!" And my impression, in a word: "I see, so that's how they went."

The newly unfolding *Evangelion* movie series has, for better or worse, the past hit of the original TV series & movies—or rather, the works that created a boom—and everyone "knows" them thoroughly in various senses. This summer, they're even rebroadcasting the original TV series on late-night terrestrial TV, partly as promotion for the theatrical release.

And I ended up watching that too, but while watching, what I thought was that it's inevitably "old" and has "limitations."

The various visual expressions that were innovative at the time were innovative by those standards, but partly because we've seen them too much, when you watch them again, in a sense they've become the standard for this type of visuals in today's era. So they still feel "old."

And the original works were still cel & film analogue production screens. While you can certainly see digital touches here and there, they were overwhelmingly creating "digital feel" with analogue technology. That was really at full capacity, hence the "limitations."

So when you ask, what should we create and show now, again? If you just brush up the visuals and effects, just tracing the same things and doing the same things would be meaningless. The first movie in the new series, 1.0, was literally the "introduction," so in a sense it needed to be "the same," but I thought this second one would be where the *Evangelion* series truly shows what it's made of.

In both good and troublesome ways, the original TV and theatrical versions are very difficult hurdles, right? You definitely have to surpass them, but just surpassing them isn't interesting either. But since there are no constraints on how you surpass them, you might as well change the rules this time.

So they changed the rules. Story reconstruction ~ new developments ~ new story, and new character arrangements.

If you do that, you win. And they won decisively. Geez. After watching, I was honestly dizzy (laughs). It's wonderful.

The people who came to watch are mostly all coming thinking they "understand" it, going "Well then, let's see what they've got." But as the story progresses, it's like "Huh? Wait wait?" and they get pleasantly "betrayed" (laughs).

"The story's completely different!" The girls watching behind me were excited as they left.

Anyway, the sheer volume, overwhelming screen density, the sharp editing that keeps pounding without pause. It was two hours that passed in a flash. And I want to see the "next" one soon (laughs).

The CG usage and photography have become even more exquisite. The colour design supporting that must have been incredibly difficult. These kinds of works must be rewarding but would be impossible for me (laughs). I'm just full of praise.

And then there's *Summer Wars*.

Before its release, I was able to attend a special preview screening and got to see it a step ahead.

And my impression.

Gahahahaha (laughs). I got taken in! Once again (laughs).

For those of us born in Showa 38 (1963), when it comes to summer anime, they were set to release in the first week of August, and it was large-scale SF anime set in the great cosmos like *Farewell to Space Battleship Yamato - Warriors of Love* and *Galaxy Express 999*. That was our middle school ~ high school era.

What Hosoda-kun, roughly the same generation as us, brought was summer vacation, countryside old house, extended family and grandma.

The virtual space world of the Web, and the real world that's now intimately linked with that virtual world. One day, a major incident in the virtual world causes major

disruptions in the real world. And to resolve that chaos, a "battle" with the virtual world unfolds from an old house in the countryside of Ueda, Nagano Prefecture—that's the story.

Since it's before release, I don't know how much I should write, but above all, it's grandma! Dignified and resolute, her figure trying to protect not just her own family but broadly "family" and "people" stirs the deep parts of our feelings. And the way of "family" connected with grandma at its peak.

It's a contrasting depiction of "family" to the earlier *Evangelion*. But I feel like the parts they're rooted in are the same.

However, the fact that there are no bad people (who don't appear) is incredibly wonderful for me.

Summer vacation, countryside old house, extended family and grandma. Actually, even before watching the main story, I was already taken in by these three things.

As someone born and raised in Tokyo, I actually never had the experience of spending summer vacation in the countryside. So it was something I longed for. Even for someone like me, there's a softness that seeps gently into the deep parts of your heart.

And grandma. Ah~, I'm weak to grandmas. I mean, grandmas are probably the strongest, greatest existence for everyone, right? It's probably grandma more than grandpa. At least for boys, grandma is truly a special top-tier existence. I was reminded of that.

With *The Girl Who Leapt Through Time*, they poked at the bittersweet feelings we left behind in our student days, and now they've hit the important parts of the distance between countryside and self, family and self from childhood to now. In any case, this

Summer Wars is an extremely striking work for "adults" including those around our generation—or rather, it's a "there he goes again (grin)" kind of work (laughs).

Actually this time, I watched it at a media preview screening, but the people on both sides of me were crying throughout the main story. As for me, I got properly taken in too.

Ah~, it's somehow frustrating (laughs). Such was this wonderful summer film.

Speaking of Hosoda-kun, it's "shadowless animation" and "atmospheric perspective transparent screen density." At first glance, in terms of volume density it seems similar to *Evangelion*, but the way density is conceived feels completely opposite.

Anyway, these are two contrasting works, *Evangelion: 2.0 You Can (Not) Advance* and *Summer Wars*. They were genuinely, without exaggeration, this summer's two recommended works.

...Ah~, still, how frustrating! (bitter laugh)

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